



IN THE WAKE · CRUISINGINTHEWAKE.COM

7-Night Western Caribbean — Hosted Solo Group

Margaritaville at Sea Islander · 7 Nights from Tampa

January 9 – 16, 2027 · Hosted by Tina Maulsby

HOSTED GROUP CRUISE
FOR MY SOLO CRUISERS GROUP!

IT'S 5 O'CLOCK
Somewhere!

Changes in
LATITUDE

GOOD VIBES
TROPICAL
DRINKS
NEW FRIENDS
AMAZING
MEMORIES

PARADISE
AWAITS
YOU!

7 DAYS OF PURE PARADISE
Let the good times set sail!

SAILING FROM
TAMPA
JAN 9-16, 2027

STOPS INCLUDE:
COZUMEL
JAMAICA
GRAND
CAYMAN

Solo Price:
\$1082
OCEAN VIEW
\$1272
BALCONY

NO WORRIES
JUST
MARGARITAS

BOOK WITH CONFIDENCE.
CRUISE WITH FRIENDS.
MEMORIES THAT LAST
FOREVER!

BOOKING INFO:
Mulsby Travel Co.
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910-528-5077
www.mulsbytravel.com

Margaritaville at Sea — the Solo Cruisers hosted group cruise flyer: 7 days round-trip from Tampa, January 9–16, 2027, calling at Grand Cayman, Ocho Rios (Jamaica), and Cozumel. Flyer courtesy Maulsby Travel Co.

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**
Hosted by **Tina Maulsby · Maulsby Travel Co.**

Welcome

Made for the solo cruiser who has already booked this specific Western Caribbean group sailing and wants one trusted read on the week — the ship, the three ports, the group's rhythm, and the winter-Caribbean caveats — in one place.

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: the **Margaritaville at Sea Islander**, sailing 7 nights round-trip from **Tampa, January 9 – 16, 2027**, calling at **Grand Cayman, Ocho Rios (Jamaica), and Cozumel (Mexico)**. It's a **hosted solo cruisers group cruise** organized and on-ship-hosted by **Tina Maulsby** at **Maulsby Travel Co.**

A note on what's first-hand here and what isn't

I haven't sailed this itinerary on this ship. Tina is the host running it, and what's framed as hers — her sailaway plan, her group meetups, her group-cruise rhythm — is from her own communications. Everything else comes from primary-source research: the cruise line's own published materials for the ship, Wikipedia for ship specs, hands-on ship reviews for venue detail, the U.S. Embassy in Kingston for the Cayman consular agency, operator price pages where excursions are quoted, and standard reference sources for currency and port logistics. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here.

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host. Use tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 for booking questions, what's bundled with your group rate, and any pre-cruise logistics. Once aboard, she's the in-person organizer — sailaway gathering, group dinners, the daily where-are-we-meeting rhythm.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads. (See our **affiliate disclosure**.)

A note on timing: January is the Caribbean’s dry season — the calm, low-humidity opposite of hurricane season. Atlantic hurricane season runs June 1 through November 30; your January window sits well clear of it. What January *can* bring is a Gulf of Mexico cold front (a “norther”) — a day of wind and a firmer ride crossing to and from Tampa — and the Caribbean stops trade a few degrees of warmth for the best underwater visibility of the year. Travel insurance is still sensible for any cruise, but the seasonal risk framing here is mild, not the storm-season vigilance a summer sailing would need. See **Section 7**.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and consulate numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake’s** companion app. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

If you’re sailing solo for the first time, you are not the only one in this group doing so. **Tina’s solo cruising stories** are worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip.

At a Glance

Ship	Margaritaville at Sea Islander (formerly <i>Costa Atlantica</i> , 2000–2023)
Cruise line	Margaritaville at Sea
Fleet role	The line’s second and larger ship (after the <i>Paradise</i>); island-casual by design
Specifications	85,619 GT · 292.56 m / 960 ft · 12 passenger decks · 2,114 guests lower berths (2,680 maximum) · 897 crew
Year built	2000 — launched 11 November 1999, delivered 2000 by Kvaerner Masa-Yards (Helsinki New Shipyard), Finland; IMO 9187796

Second life	Entered Margaritaville at Sea service June 2024 after conversion from <i>Costa Atlantica</i>
Christening (as Margaritaville)	June 10, 2024
Godmother	Savannah Buffett — daughter of Margaritaville founder Jimmy Buffett
Original christening	July 17, 2000 as <i>Costa Atlantica</i> , godmother Claudia Cardinale (Italian actress)
Departure port	Port Tampa Bay, Tampa, Florida
Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Western Caribbean round-trip
Audience	Solo travelers (hosted group)
Group host	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. — tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077 (on-ship + booking)
Group solo rates	Ocean View \$1,082 · Balcony \$1,272 (per the group flyer; verify with Tina; Interior may be available below Ocean View)
Dress code	Casual — no formal nights
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The stops for the January 9 – 16, 2027 sailing:

1. **Tampa, Florida** — embark Sat Jan 9 · evening sailaway
2. **Cruising at sea** — Sun Jan 10
3. **Grand Cayman** — Mon Jan 11 (tender port)
4. **Ocho Rios, Jamaica** — Tue Jan 12
5. **Cruising at sea** — Wed Jan 13
6. **Cozumel, Mexico** — Thu Jan 14
7. **Cruising at sea** — Fri Jan 15
8. **Tampa, Florida** — disembark Sat Jan 16

Verify your specific day order in your Margaritaville at Sea booking materials.

Margaritaville publishes the exact port sequence with your reservation; the order above is a reasonable Western Caribbean pattern from Tampa, not a live schedule. Track the ship's real position any time from the **Ship Tracker**.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: Margaritaville at Sea Islander

A well-traveled hull with a second, easier life

The Margaritaville at Sea Islander is a mid-size ship — 85,619 gross tons, 12 passenger decks, 2,114 guests at lower berths (2,680 at full occupancy), and 897 crew. She was built in 2000 by Kvaerner Masa-Yards at the Helsinki New Shipyard in Finland and sailed her first twenty-three years as *Costa Atlantica* for Italy's Costa Cruises. Margaritaville at Sea acquired and converted her, and she entered service under her present name in June 2024 — christened **June 10, 2024**, with **Savannah Buffett**, daughter of Margaritaville founder Jimmy Buffett, as godmother. (Her first christening was July 17, 2000, as *Costa Atlantica*, sponsored by the Italian actress Claudia Cardinale.)

What that history means for you: this is not a brand-new megaship, and she isn't trying to be. She's a comfortable, walkable, thoroughly shaken-down vessel whose crew rhythms are long settled, wrapped in a laid-back island theme. If you've sailed the newest 5,000-guest ships, the Islander will feel smaller and calmer — fewer crowds at the elevators, a shorter walk from anywhere to anywhere, and an unhurried tempo that suits a solo week. For a side-by-side sense of her scale against the megaships, the **Ship Size Atlas** shows the real relative proportions. For where the major lines are pointing their Caribbean deployments in 2026–27, **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** is the wider context.

The Margaritaville character — what it actually means aboard

The theme is the point, and it's consistent: **casual, no formal nights, “it's five o'clock somewhere.”** You will not need a jacket. The whole ship is built around the idea of an easy beach vacation that happens to float. Practically, that shows up as:

- **Three pools**, each with a hot tub: the **LandShark Pool** (main outdoor), the **5 o'Clock Somewhere Pool** (with a retractable roof for cooler or breezy days — useful on a January crossing), and the adults-only **Tiki Bar Pool** aft.
- **A deck full of themed bars** — the 5 o'Clock Somewhere Bar, LandShark Bar, Tiki Bar, a sports bar, a speakeasy, and a top-deck nightclub among them. Island music is a near-constant.
- **Fins Up Fitness Center** (free), the paid **St. Somewhere Spa**, mini-golf, pickleball, cornhole, and a **Love & Luck Casino**.
- **Stars on the Water Theater** for the evening production shows, plus the trivia / game-show / live-music circuit that fills a sea day.

Cabin categories — the solo calculus

The group flyer shows two solo tiers: **Ocean View \$1,082** and **Balcony \$1,272**. The ship's full range is Interior (windowless), Ocean View (window), Balcony/veranda, and Suites, plus eight accessible cabins (four interior, four ocean-view). Two quick reads for a solo traveler:

- **Ocean View at \$1,082** — a real window and natural daylight for the lowest solo price on the flyer. On a warm-water winter itinerary where you'll spend most waking hours out of the cabin, this is the sensible price-leader. Interior may be bookable below this through Tina's block if budget is the deciding factor — ask.
- **Balcony at \$1,272** — a private outdoor space, which on a Caribbean cruise earns its keep more than on a cold-weather sailing: morning coffee in the trade winds, a quiet place to decompress after a port day, evenings outside with a book. **The ~\$190 differential is the question.** If you're only in the cabin to sleep, Ocean View wins. If a private deck would change the texture of your week and the math works, the balcony is a modest step up here.

Unlike some lines' dedicated solo "studio" cabins, Margaritaville doesn't publish a no-single-supplement product; the solo pricing on this sailing is what **Tina negotiated for the group block** — confirm exactly what's included with her before you commit.

Before you commit, run the stateroom sanity check — a four-question filter that catches the bookings most likely to leave a cruiser unhappy (it's the one that flags whether a windowless interior will bother you). Once chosen, the **cabin organization guide** covers small-space pragmatics — over-the-door organizers, a few magnetic hooks, the packing-cube discipline that makes a compact cabin livable.

Dining

The Islander's dining is **mostly complimentary, casual, and generous with variety**:

Included with your fare (no extra charge):

- **The main dining room** — full-service breakfast, lunch, and dinner; classics like shrimp and steak alongside Caribbean specialties. The multi-course sit-down, no reservation fee.

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- **Port of Indecision Buffet** — the standard buffet for breakfast, lunch, and dinner; the reliable fallback.
 - **Cheeseburger in Paradise** — the poolside burger stand (yes, named for the song).
 - **Mexican Cutie** — casual Mexican fare.
 - **Frank & Lola's Pizzeria** — pizza that reviewers rate among the best at sea, open late.
 - **Soft-serve** by the pool.

Specialty / à la carte (extra charge):

- **JWB Prime Steakhouse** — a four-course dinner around \$55/person; the ship's dress-up-a-little night if you want one.
- **Far Side Sushi** — rolls (~\$10), poke, sashimi.
- **Island East** — Maine lobster roll (~\$18), ceviche (~\$10), snow crab at market price.
- **Tiki Grill** — wings, conch fritters (~\$8).
- **Margaritaville Coffee Shop** — espresso drinks (\$3–\$9), pastries (\$3–\$6).

Drinks. Margaritaville sells beverage packages rather than bundling them. A soda package runs about \$10 per person per night; the alcohol package on a short sailing works out to roughly \$88/day per person (18% gratuity included, with a daily drink cap). The signature souvenir blender cup is about \$30 with the first drink included. Whether a package pays off depends entirely on how much you actually drink — put your real pattern into the **drink-calculator** and see the breakeven before you buy. The companion article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks the math with worked examples.

The Day 1 mistake to avoid: don't sign up for a drink package at the bar on embarkation afternoon on impulse. Decide before you board, ideally with the drink-calculator math already done. It's easy to buy the package in a sailaway mood and use it far less than you imagined.

Connectivity at sea

Wi-Fi is sold in tiers — roughly \$72 basic and \$88 premium (with streaming) when pre-purchased on a short sailing; a 7-night rate will differ, so check current pricing at booking. The **internet at sea guide** covers the cross-line baselines and how to avoid

surprise cellular roaming charges in port. For most solo cruisers in the group: use the basic tier if you buy anything, don't try to stream at sea, lean on port-day cellular where your plan covers it, and keep one trusted person ashore updated with a daily one-line message — see **Section 6**.

Section 2 — Day by Day

This day-by-day uses a typical Western-Caribbean-from-Tampa rhythm. **Verify your specific times and the exact port order in your Margaritaville at Sea booking** — the published sequence can differ, and January cold fronts occasionally nudge a departure time.

Build each port day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore, and record what actually happened in the **Port Logbook** on the way back.

Day 1 — Saturday, January 9 — Tampa (embarkation)



Port Tampa Bay and the Tampa waterfront — embarkation day for the Margaritaville at Sea Islander

Terminal: Port Tampa Bay cruise terminal (confirm your specific terminal in your Margaritaville booking documents).

Getting to the port:

- **Tampa International (TPA) → Port Tampa Bay:** about 20 minutes; rideshare typically \$20–35.
- **If driving:** the port's cruise terminals have paid parking (reserve ahead in peak weeks).
- **Embark window:** typically early afternoon; watch your assigned check-in time. The Islander sails in the **evening** from Tampa.

Pre-cruise hotel — recommended. A January flight delay is less weather-fraught than a summer one, but a same-day arrival to an evening sailaway still leaves no margin if a flight slips. Flying into Tampa the day before (Friday Jan 8) and staying near the waterfront or downtown removes the risk and lets you start the trip unhurried. Confirm Tina's pre-cruise meetup plans before you book the hotel. The **Tampa port page** covers the walkable downtown, the Riverwalk, and Ybor City if you build in an extra day.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **Check-in** at your assigned window; complete online check-in in advance to skip a queue.
- **Aboard:** drop carry-ons, find lunch at the buffet or a poolside stand while cabins are still being readied.
- **Cabin ready:** meet your stateroom steward; drop bags.
- **Muster drill:** the mandatory safety briefing before sailaway — follow the instructions in your cruise materials.
- **Evening sailaway:** Tina's group gathers before departure — watch her communications for the exact spot and time. A Tampa departure runs down the bay past the channel markers; it's a mellow, pretty start.
- **Dinner:** join the group's first dinner if Tina has set one, or eat casual at the buffet or Frank & Lola's. This is the night to find the Solo Cruisers meetup and put faces to names.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive), a light layer (January evenings on deck can be breezy), **all medications**, a change of clothes, **passport** (preferred — Cayman, Jamaica, and Mexico are foreign ports and a passport is the cleanest documentation), phone charger, refillable water

bottle. Checked bags may not reach your cabin until evening. For a fuller walk-through of what embarkation day actually feels like, **Embarkation Day: What to Expect** is the primer.

Money/card: your Margaritaville keycard is your ID, room key, and onboard charge account. **Currency aboard: US Dollar.**

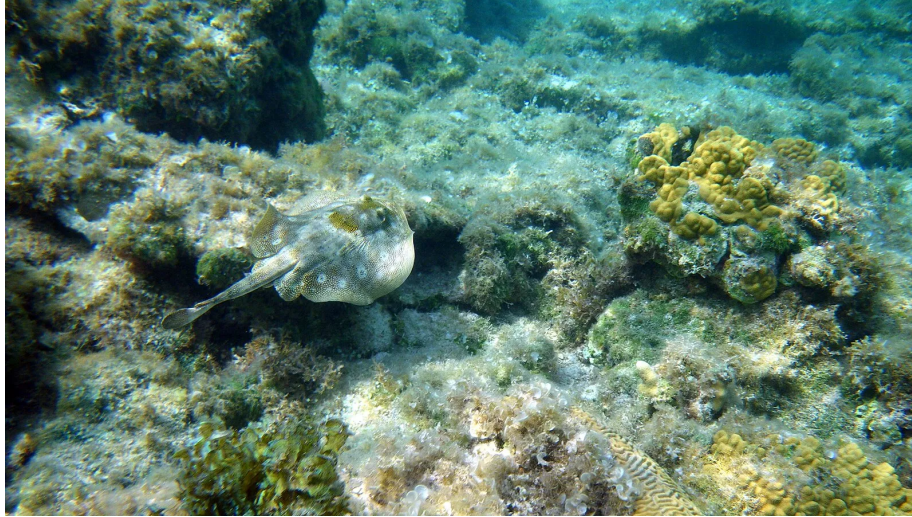
Day 2 — Sunday, January 10 — Cruising at sea

The settling-in day, heading south across the Gulf of Mexico toward the Yucatán Channel.

- **Morning:** breakfast at the buffet or main dining room; find a lounge chair. If a January norther is blowing, the 5 o’Clock Somewhere Pool’s retractable roof is the comfortable option.
- **Midday:** the pool circuit, a spa day-pass (sea-day mornings are when introductory rates appear), or the port talk for Grand Cayman.
- **Afternoon:** trivia, live music, mini-golf or pickleball on the top deck, or simply the rail and the wake.
- **Evening:** the group’s dinner if Tina has set one; a production show at Stars on the Water Theater; the bar or nightclub circuit if that’s your speed.

This is the day the group forms. If you’re shy, the sea day’s low-stakes activities — trivia teams, a shared table at dinner — are the easiest on-ramps.

Day 3 — Monday, January 11 — Grand Cayman



George Town, Grand Cayman — the cruise tender port, with Seven Mile Beach beyond

Tender port — Grand Cayman has no cruise pier; ships anchor offshore and tenders run to George Town. Plan for a 20–30 minute end-to-end tender at peak. **Earlier tenders are faster.**

Grand Cayman — the most expensive port of the week, and the one with the strongest currency. A British Overseas Territory of about 74,000 people. The Caymans use the **Cayman Islands dollar (KYD)**, **pegged at 1 KYD = 1.20 USD since 1974** — meaning the Cayman dollar is *stronger* than the U.S. dollar. USD is universally accepted, but change usually comes back in KYD at a practical rate of about \$1 USD ≈ \$0.80 KYD; pay \$24 USD on a \$20 KYD bill and the math works out even. **Seven Mile Beach** is the postcard stretch of west-coast white sand running north from George Town, the capital and cruise hub.

Free, walkable from George Town:

- **George Town** — the duty-free district at the tender drop, the small downtown waterfront, and the **Cayman Islands National Museum** (~\$10).

Paid (decide ahead):

- **Stingray City Sandbar** — the iconic Grand Cayman experience: stand in waist-deep clear water surrounded by tame Southern stingrays. Independent operators run tours for ~\$60/person; ship excursions \$80–130. **The trip that converts non-snorkelers.** 2–3 hours.

- **Seven Mile Beach** — a ~\$5 #1 bus or ~\$20 taxi from George Town; the beach is public (free entry), a chair at a beach club \$10–20. The lower-effort half-day.
- **Cayman Turtle Centre** — conservation-and-interaction park; ~\$45 entry; a fuller day with shuttle.

For first-time Grand Cayman: Stingray City is the trip-defining choice. If you've done it, Seven Mile Beach (cheap by bus or taxi) is the easy default, and the National Museum is a quiet half-hour if a squall passes through. Worth a look before you go: the **Grand Cayman port page**, its **photo gallery**, and the **Grand Cayman logbook**.

Pack for Grand Cayman: swimsuit, water shoes (the Stingray City sandbar is wading-friendly but nearby reef has coral), reef-safe sunscreen (Cayman reef is protected), sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash, and an underwater camera if you have one.

Day 4 — Tuesday, January 12 — Ocho Rios, Jamaica



Ocho Rios, Jamaica — the north-coast cruise port and green hills beyond

Arrival: morning. Ocho Rios is a major cruise port on Jamaica's north coast, with the **Island Village** shopping-and-dining complex right at the pier — air-conditioned, walkable, with beach access, and the low-stress easy-day option if you'd rather not book a tour.

Ocho Rios — Jamaica’s north-coast adventure port. Its signature attraction is **Dunn’s River Falls**, a 600-foot tiered waterfall you climb, cold spring-water running over the terraces year-round. Outside the developed port and resort strip you’ll see a working Jamaican town — neither cruise-polished nor “dangerous,” just a real place.

Free / low-cost, near the pier:

- **Island Village** — shops, restaurants, and beach access, walkable from the ship.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **Dunn’s River Falls** — the famous climb; ship excursion ~\$60–90, independent operators less. Water shoes required.
- **Mystic Mountain** — bobsled, zipline, and chairlift through the rainforest canopy; ~\$110–130 ship.
- **Blue Hole (Island Gully Falls)** — a quieter, more natural waterfall-and-swimming-hole experience; independent tours ~\$50–80.
- **All-inclusive resort day-pass** — a beach, pool, lunch, and drinks day for ~\$80–120; the lowest-stress choice.

For first-time Ocho Rios: if you want the postcard, Dunn’s River is it — but it’s a busy, physical climb. If you’d rather a calmer day, the Blue Hole or a resort day-pass trade the crowds for quiet. Worth a look: the **Ocho Rios port page** and the broader **Jamaica coverage**.

Pack for Jamaica: swimsuit worn or in your day-bag, **water shoes** (Dunn’s requires them), reef-safe sunscreen, sun hat, a light cover-up, \$40–60 USD in small bills (USD widely accepted; Jamaican dollar not necessary), and your phone in a waterproof pouch.

Day 5 — Wednesday, January 13 — Cruising at sea

The middle sea day, repositioning northwest toward the Yucatán and Cozumel. By now the group’s rhythm is familiar.

- **Morning:** your found spot on deck, a spa treatment if you skipped Day 2, or the Cozumel port talk.
- **Afternoon:** pool deck (quietest 2–4 PM after the lunch peak), the casino, or an indoor diversion if a front has the wind up.

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- **Evening:** the group dinner, a specialty night at JWB Prime Steakhouse if you want to dress up a little, and the theater show.

Day 6 — Thursday, January 14 — Cozumel, Mexico



Cozumel's coastal road and the reef offshore — the Western Caribbean's signature snorkel destination

Arrival: morning; Cozumel is often a later-departure port. Ships dock at one of three piers — **Punta Langosta** (downtown), the **International Pier**, or **Puerta Maya**. Check your cruise app. Cozumel is the most heavily visited Caribbean port; expect several ships in port the same day.

Cozumel — the underwater destination of the Western Caribbean. The reef off Cozumel — protected within **Cozumel Reefs National Park since 1996** — delivers visibility consistently among the best in the Caribbean, and January's dry-season clarity is the best of the year. If anyone in the group has ever wanted to try snorkeling, **this is the day for it.**

Easy-day option (no excursion):

- Stay near your pier. **Punta Langosta** puts you directly in downtown San Miguel — walk around, find a real Mexican lunch (\$15–25 at a non-tourist restaurant), and

shop the **Mercado Municipal** (the local market, not the pier tourist shops). The International and Puerta Maya piers are a ~\$10 taxi from downtown.

Half-day options:

- **Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park** (~\$50 entry, ~15 min by taxi) — calm water, easy reef snorkeling, loungers; the family-friendly, low-effort choice.
- **Paradise Beach** (small entry with a food/drink minimum, ~15 min by taxi) — a lower-key beach-club day.

Full-day options:

- **Palancar Reef snorkel tour** — *the iconic Cozumel trip*. Pier operators run it for \$40–60/person (ship excursion \$80–110); a two-hour tour in calm, fish-heavy water. **The trip that converts non-snorkelers**. Bring an underwater camera — the **cruise-tech and photography guide** covers waterproof cases and mounts if you want to think it through before packing.
- **Tulum ruins** (ferry + bus; \$90–150 ship or ~\$80 independent) — a long day; even in January the midday sun is strong, so pace it.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel's piers are accessible; Punta Langosta connects to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Many beach clubs offer beach wheelchairs — ask ahead. Snorkel *boats* are typically not accessible; book a beach-snorkel instead. The **disability-at-sea guide** covers the broader accessibility picture.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen (locally enforced), water shoes, sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash, and a small underwater camera. Worth a look: the **Cozumel port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Cozumel logbook**.

Day 7 — Friday, January 15 — Cruising at sea

The last full day, heading north through the Yucatán Channel and back across the Gulf toward Tampa. Pack in the calm, settle your onboard account, and set out your tagged debark bags before the night's deadline. Tonight's group gathering is the last-night-together dinner — make it if you can.

Day 8 — Saturday, January 16 — Tampa (debarkation)

The realistic timeline:

- **Early breakfast** at the buffet or main dining room.
- **Self-disembarkation** begins after the ship clears customs; walk-off proceeds in waves, and all guests are typically off by mid-morning.

The bag situation. The night before, you place tagged checked luggage outside your cabin door by the posted deadline; bags go ashore overnight and you collect them in the terminal before customs. Keep a change of clothes, all medications, passport, and valuables in your carry-on.

Getting from Port Tampa Bay to TPA:

- **Rideshare/taxi:** ~20 minutes, \$20–35.
 - **Killing a few hours before an afternoon flight:** the **Tampa Riverwalk**, Ybor City's historic district, or the Florida Aquarium near the port are all easy fills.
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Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

Work the **countdown page** alongside this list if you like a running checklist.

6+ months before — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm the booking with Tina.** Cabin category, final price, and exactly what's included in the group rate (gratuities? any beverage or Wi-Fi credit? any bundled perks?).
- **Buy travel insurance.** Sensible for any cruise. January is outside hurricane season, so this is standard trip-interruption/medical coverage, not the storm-specific policy a summer sailing needs.
- **Plan flights to Tampa (TPA).** Arrive at minimum the day before sailing (Friday Jan 8, 2027).

4 months before — soft logistics

- **Online check-in** in your Margaritaville account when it opens; complete the health questions close to sailing.
- **Specialty dining and excursions.** Book JWB Prime Steakhouse if you want a set night; reserve ship excursions, or line up independent operators for Grand Cayman, Ocho Rios, and Cozumel.

2 months before — final commitments

- **Confirm gratuities** — whether they're pre-paid in your group rate or billed aboard (see [Section 5](#)).
- **Beverage / Wi-Fi packages** if you want them — decide with the **drink-calculator**, don't impulse-buy aboard.
- **Confirm your pre-cruise hotel** and begin the **packing list**. The site's **packing-lists** hub has printable versions.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Photocopy your passport** — keep the copy in your cabin, separate from the passport.
- **Print the emergency handoff card** and share it with one trusted person ashore.
- **Confirm Tina's group rhythm** — sailaway gathering spot and time, Day 1 dinner plan.

14 days before

- **Online check-in closes** ahead of sailing — complete it early.
- **Save boarding documents** offline in your phone.
- **Begin physical packing.**

Day before — Tampa arrival

- **Fly into TPA Friday Jan 8.**
- **Check into your hotel;** confirm Saturday-morning porter/rideshare timing.

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for a January Western Caribbean sailing)

This list is tuned for: **early-to-mid January, Western Caribbean from Tampa** — Tampa embarkation cool-to-mild (roughly 55–72°F, breezy), Caribbean ports warm and dry (roughly 78–83°F daytime, low humidity, water temperature ~79–81°F), calm-to-occasionally-breezy seas, best snorkeling visibility of the year. **Three port days** — two mostly beach/water, one adventure. **Three sea days. Casual dress culture — no formal nights.**

Documents and money

- **Passport** (strongly preferred for this itinerary)
- Photocopy of passport (separate location)
- Travel insurance policy + emergency phone number (printed)
- Credit card + debit card (separate locations)
- **\$150–250 USD cash** in small bills (\$1s, \$5s, \$10s) for tips, taxis, and small purchases ashore
- Boarding documents (saved offline in your phone)
- Group itinerary from Tina

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications in original prescription bottles
- Phone + charger + power bank
- Refillable water bottle
- **A light layer / sweater** (Tampa evenings and a breezy Gulf crossing can be cool; ship interiors run cold)
- Swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive)
- Change of clothes (in case a checked bag is delayed)

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- Sunglasses, sun hat, reef-safe sunscreen (enforced in Cozumel and Cayman)
 - Reading material

Daytime — port and ship

- **4–5 swimsuits** (you'll be in water most port days; rotating suits is a real quality-of-life upgrade)
- **2 swim cover-ups**
- **3–4 quick-dry t-shirts or tank tops**
- **2 pairs lightweight shorts**
- **1–2 pairs lightweight pants** (cooler evenings, adventure excursions)
- **1 light long-sleeve shirt** (sun protection; a cool sea-day morning)
- **1 light cardigan or wrap** (ship AC; breezy top-deck evenings)

Evening — ship dining

- **4–5 casual outfits** — Margaritaville has **no formal nights**; sundresses, nice shorts or slacks with a decent top, an island shirt. Genuinely casual.
- **1 slightly dressier outfit** if you want one for a JWB Prime Steakhouse night — nothing formal required
- Comfortable shoes for carpeted corridors

Footwear

- **Comfortable walking shoes** — ship corridors, dry port time
- **Water shoes** — required for Dunn's River Falls; useful for Cozumel/Cayman reef
- **Flip-flops** — pool deck and cabin
- One casual pair for the evenings

Toiletries

- All prescription medications (in original bottles, in your carry-on)
- OTC standbys: Tylenol, Advil, Imodium, Benadryl, **Bonine or Dramamine** (see **Section 7**)

-
- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30+; **reef-safe enforced in Cozumel and Cayman**)
 - After-sun aloe gel
 - Toothbrush, toothpaste, deodorant, basic toiletries
 - Lip balm with SPF

Accessories and essentials

- Polarized sunglasses; brimmed sun hat
- Small daypack for port days
- **Waterproof phone case** — snorkel days and the odd Caribbean shower
- **Small dry bag (~5L)** — for excursions where you don't want a wet bag on the beach
- Power adapter (US outlets aboard; standard US plugs are fine)
- Pen + small notebook if you keep a logbook

Skip — what NOT to bring

- **Iron or steamer** — prohibited in cabins; the ship provides facilities
 - **Candles** — prohibited (fire hazard)
 - **Heavy jewelry** — leave high-value pieces home
 - **Formalwear** — there are no formal nights on this ship
 - **Beach umbrella / pop-up shade** — beach clubs and the pool deck cover this
-

Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The numbers below are calibrated for this specific sailing. For a total tuned to your own cabin, drinking habits, excursion appetite, and tipping pattern, the **cruise-budget-calculator** builds a personalized figure — usually within about 5% of what you'll actually spend if you input honestly.

What's included in your fare

The group rate covers:

- Your cabin (Ocean View or Balcony per the flyer; Interior if Tina has it in the block)
- All meals at the main dining room, the Port of Indecision Buffet, and the complimentary poolside spots (Cheeseburger in Paradise, Mexican Cutie, Frank & Lola's)
- Onboard entertainment at the Stars on the Water Theater and the daytime activity circuit
- Pools, hot tubs, and the Fins Up Fitness Center
- Tendering (needed at Grand Cayman)
- Cabin steward and dining-room service
- **Confirm with Tina** whether your group rate bundles any gratuities, beverage credit, or Wi-Fi

What's NOT included

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Gratuities (if not pre-paid)	~\$154 — \$22/person/night × 7 (staterooms); \$25/night in suites
Beverage package (if you want one)	~\$70 soda for the week, up to ~\$600+ for a full alcohol package
Wi-Fi package	varies by tier — confirm the 7-night rate at booking
Specialty dining	\$0–110 — JWB Prime Steakhouse ~\$55; sushi/à la carte extras
Shore excursion — Grand Cayman	\$0–130 — Stingray City ~\$60 indep / \$80–130 ship; Seven Mile Beach taxi ~\$20
Shore excursion — Ocho Rios	\$0–130 — Dunn's River ~\$60–90; Mystic Mountain ~\$110–130; resort day-pass ~\$80–120

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Shore excursion — Cozumel	\$0–110 — Palancar snorkel ~\$50 indep / ~\$95 ship; Chankanaab ~\$50; Tulum ~\$120
Spa treatments	\$0–400 — massages \$130–200; thermal/day passes vary
Casino / arcade	as you go
Travel insurance	\$60–150 per person (standard, non-storm-season)
Pre-cruise hotel (Tampa)	~\$120–200
Airport transfers TPA ↔ port	~\$40–70 round trip

A realistic mid-range solo budget (per person, on top of cruise fare)

Item	Cost
Gratuities (\$22 × 7)	\$154
Beverage (moderate drinker, package or à la carte)	\$250
Wi-Fi	\$100
Specialty dining (one JWB night)	\$55
Grand Cayman: Stingray City + lunch	\$80
Ocho Rios: Dunn's River + lunch	\$80
Cozumel: Palancar snorkel + lunch	\$80
Travel insurance	\$90
Pre-cruise hotel (Tampa)	\$150
Airport transfers	\$60
Total above fare	~\$1,099

Frugal version (skip the beverage package, beach-day choices everywhere, minimal Wi-Fi): ~\$450 above fare.

Splurge version (balcony upgrade already booked, spa days, private tours, the full drink package): **\$1,800–2,800 above fare.**

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** covers the gratuity math specifically; **Cruise Tipping 2026** explains why Margaritaville's \$22/night rate is currently the industry's highest and how the major lines compare.

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. Fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
CABIN: _____
SHIP: Margaritaville at Sea Islander
LINE: Margaritaville at Sea
SAILING: January 9 – 16, 2027
FROM: Port Tampa Bay, Tampa, Florida, USA
ITINERARY: Tampa → Grand Cayman → Ocho Rios
(Jamaica) → Cozumel (Mexico) → Tampa
GROUP HOST: Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.
tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
contact the cruise line through official
channels):
+1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
+1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

CRUISE LINE (booking / guest services):
Margaritaville at Sea: 1 (800) 814-7100
(verify the current number on your booking
confirmation before sailing)

NEAREST EMBASSY/CONSULATE BY PORT:
Tampa, FL – US domestic; call 911
Grand Cayman – US Consular Agency,
George Town:
+1 (345) 747-8172
(Mon-Fri 8 AM-2 PM)
After hours: US Embassy
Kingston +1 (876) 702-6000
Ocho Rios, Jamaica – US Embassy Kingston:
+1 (876) 702-6000
Cozumel, Mexico – US Consulate Mérida:
+1 (844) 528-6611 (US) / 999 689-0660;
Cancún Consular Agency:
+1 (844) 528-6611 (US)

CRUISER MEDICAL:
Allergies: _____
Medications: _____
Conditions: _____
Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:

Track at: /tools/ship-tracker.html
 or marinetraffic.com
 (search "Margaritaville at Sea Islander")

What an at-home contact does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable; silence usually means signal, not emergency.
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — they can locate the ship and reach the cruise line through official channels at no cost. For a non-urgent message, call Margaritaville at Sea guest services.
3. **Reach Tina** at tina@maulsbytravel.com or 910-528-5077 — she's both your booking agent and your on-ship host.
4. **If there's been an incident:** US Coast Guard for US waters; US Consular Agency George Town for Grand Cayman (US Embassy Kingston after hours); US Embassy Kingston for Jamaica; US Consulate Mérida for Mexico; ship's medical for health emergencies.
5. **Track the ship's position** at </tools/ship-tracker.html>.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in your cabin)
 - Photocopy of passport (separate from the passport)
 - Travel insurance policy number (printed)
 - This handoff card, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person ashore
-

Section 7 — Seasickness + Winter Caribbean Weather

The good news first: January is the Caribbean's dry season — the calm, low-humidity, storm-free window. Atlantic hurricane season runs June 1 through November 30; your sailing is comfortably outside it. That single fact makes this a gentle week to sail.

What January weather actually does

- **The Caribbean ports (Grand Cayman, Ocho Rios, Cozumel)** are warm and dry — daytime around 78–83°F, low humidity, and the clearest underwater visibility of the year. Rain is brief and occasional, not the daily afternoon downpour of summer.
- **The Gulf of Mexico can send a cold front south** — a “norther.” When one passes, Tampa turns cool and breezy for a day and the crossing to or from the Caribbean can get a firmer ride and some swell. It's a comfort question, not a safety one; the ship handles it routinely, and it usually clears within a day.
- **Tampa itself in January** is mild-to-cool — pack a real layer for embarkation and debarkation evenings.

Seasickness onboard

Most of this week is calm. The two spots to watch for motion are the **Gulf crossings on Day 2 and Day 7**, especially if a front is passing. A mid-size ship like the Islander is steady in normal winter conditions.

If you're prone to motion sickness:

- **Bonine (meclizine)** — once-daily, less drowsy than Dramamine.
- **Sea-Bands (acupressure wristbands)** — many find them effective.
- **Ginger** (capsules, tea, candies) — mild but real.
- **Scopolamine patches** (prescription, behind-the-ear) — the strongest option; 3-day duration.

-
- **Stay mid-ship and low** in your cabin choice — mid-ship, lower-to-middle decks feel the least motion.

The article **Cruise Seasickness: What Actually Works** goes deeper on prevention and the timing that matters (start remedies *before* you feel it, not after).

If a front changes a port day — the solo + hosted-group playbook

Winter fronts rarely cancel a Caribbean call, but a rough tender morning at Grand Cayman is possible. A few things to know:

- **What the line refunds vs. what insurance covers.** If a port is skipped for weather, the cruise line typically refunds prepaid *ship-sold* excursions for that port to your onboard account. Excursions booked directly with independent operators are between you and the operator — refund terms vary, and not all are weather-refundable. Screenshot every independent booking confirmation before you sail. This is what a trip-interruption rider is for.
 - **How Tina will signal a change.** Her group dinner is the predictable in-person channel; expect her to use it for live updates. Email and text reach her ashore; once sailing, the ship's onboard messaging is the more reliable in-cabin path. If her communication goes quiet during a weather situation, the Captain's daily announcement and the printed daily program carry the same official changes.
 - **Don't make irrevocable decisions in port on a bad-weather day.** If a posted departure moves earlier, the all-aboard time shortens; the be-back-30-minutes-early rule gets tighter. Politely insist on an early return if an operator is stretching the tour as conditions turn.
-

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Cell service and roaming

- **At sea** — ship Wi-Fi only; keep airplane mode ON. Cellular via the ship's onboard tower roams at a steep per-minute rate.
- **Grand Cayman** — Flow and Digicel are the carriers; check your plan's roaming.
- **Ocho Rios, Jamaica** — Digicel and Flow; some US plans include Jamaica roaming, others sell a ~\$10/day pass.
- **Cozumel** — Telcel and AT&T Mexico; US T-Mobile often includes Mexico roaming, Verizon/AT&T-US sell ~\$10/day passes.

The **internet at sea guide** has the cross-line detail.

Currency

- **Aboard:** US Dollar.
- **Grand Cayman:** Cayman Islands dollar (KYD) is local and **stronger** than USD (pegged 1 KYD = 1.20 USD since 1974). USD accepted everywhere; change usually comes back in KYD at a practical \$1 USD ≈ \$0.80 KYD. Cards everywhere.
- **Ocho Rios, Jamaica:** USD widely accepted; Jamaican dollar (JMD) not necessary. Small bills are best.
- **Cozumel, Mexico:** USD accepted at tourist-facing businesses; the Mexican peso (MXN) gets better prices off the tourist track. Cards at sit-downs; ATMs at the pier carry a fee.

Tipping ashore

- **Grand Cayman:** 15% standard on bills; \$5/person on Stingray City for the guide who takes your photo.
- **Ocho Rios:** 10–15% on bills; \$2–5/person on guided tours; a few dollars to the Dunn's River guide who leads your chain up the falls.

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- **Cozumel:** 10–15% on restaurant bills; 10–20 pesos for taxi drivers; \$5–10/person for half-day tours.

Onboard tipping

Margaritaville at Sea's daily gratuity is **\$22 per person, per night** for staterooms and **\$25 per person, per night** for suites — as of February 1, 2026, the highest daily rate in the cruise industry. The line does not allow guests to adjust or remove it. **Confirm with Tina whether your group rate has it pre-paid**, and note that pre-paying at booking generally locks your rate against future increases. Extra cash for standout service is appreciated but not expected:

- Stateroom attendant: \$20–40 cash at the end of the week
- A bartender who remembers your order: \$1–2 per drink in cash

The **cruise-tipping-calculator** runs the total; **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the broader context on how and why 2026 gratuities landed where they did.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Tina is both your booking agent and your on-ship host. She sets the rhythm. The typical pattern:

- **Day 1 sailaway** — Tina hosts a gathering before the evening departure. Watch her communications for the exact spot and time.
- **A standing group dinner** — Tina usually anchors the group with a nightly dinner at a set time so people can find each other. Show up to whichever nights work for you; it's free with your fare and there's no per-night reservation.
- **Group activities** — she may add a specialty dinner, hosted trivia, or a spa day; check her communications.
- **Port days** — most hosted groups don't require a port-day group activity; you're on your own schedule unless a specific excursion is being organized.

-
- **Last-night dinner** — the Friday-night gathering (after Cozumel) is the traditional send-off.

How to find Tina on Day 1. Watch her email or Facebook for the sailaway spot and time. If you don't see anything before boarding, the pool deck or the main atrium bar near sailaway is the likeliest place to find the group.

How the group actually works — the unwritten part

The schedule above is the written part. The unwritten part is what most first-time hosted-group cruisers actually wonder about, so here it is plainly:

- **Every event is opt-in, and opting out costs you nothing.** Skip tomorrow's dinner because you'd rather eat poolside with a book? Nobody logs it. The standing dinner exists so the group can find each other at a predictable time — not so attendance can be taken. You'll see everyone again.
 - **"No thanks, I'm doing my own thing today" is a complete sentence.** On a solo group cruise specifically, everyone aboard has needed alone-time at some point — they recognize it and don't take it personally. Tina won't either.
 - **Dinner-table norms.** Sit anywhere the group is sitting; there's no fixed seating and no group menu. On nights you skip the group, the buffet and the casual poolside spots make solo dining low-friction.
 - **Port-day friendliness is not a port-week commitment.** Sharing a taxi to Stingray City on Monday doesn't obligate you to anyone's Cozumel plan on Thursday. Pairings form and re-form all week; that's the design.
 - **A group this size produces a few real connections, not a crowd of them.** A hosted solo week tends to yield two or three friendships that outlast the trip and a circle of friendly faces. That's a good outcome — don't measure the week against "everyone became best friends."
-

Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

Margaritaville at Sea leans casual and social, which suits solo travelers well — no formal-night pressure, an easy poolside-bar culture, and a mid-size ship where you run into the same faces and the group stays findable.

For first-time solo cruisers:

- Tina runs **welcoming, low-pressure** group cruises. Show up when you want, skip when you want.
- The first-night group meetup is the easiest way to find your people in the first 24 hours.
- The **Solo Cruising Practical Guide** covers the broader rhythm and the small social moves that make a solo week feel right.

Solo cruising stories. Tina has written extensively on solo cruising — her **solo cruising hub** collects the practical, the emotional, and the social rhythms across multiple sailings. Worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip.

If you're sailing this one to mark a transition

Some readers of this pack are solo because of where life has put them — a recent loss, a marriage that ended, a long stretch of caregiving that finally has a quiet week in it. The Western Caribbean in January is a gentle week for that kind of trip: warm water, calm sea days, an unrushed pace, and a hosted group whose composition tilts in the same direction. Tina's broader writing on the **solo hub** — particularly **In the Wake of Grief** — names this directly; this pack won't repeat what she's already said well. If that's why you booked, the resources are there to read at your pace.

Solo safety — cabin and onboard

Solo cruising is overwhelmingly safe — cruise ships are among the most surveilled travel environments anywhere, with CCTV in common areas, 24-hour security, controlled deck access, and crew trained in emergency response. The Cruise Vessel

Security and Safety Act (US federal law since 2010) mandates camera coverage and reporting obligations. None of this makes risk zero, but the baseline is high. A few habits still make sense:

Your cabin door. Use the deadbolt and privacy latch at night. Some solo cruisers add a portable door wedge — under \$10, takes no space, and calming for anyone who sleeps uneasily in an unfamiliar room.

Share your itinerary before sailing. Send the day-by-day to one trusted person ashore, with your cabin number once assigned and your insurance policy number. The family handoff card in **Section 6** is built for exactly that — including the State Department’s 24/7 line, which can locate the ship at no cost to your family.

Friendliness is not obligation. A good conversation at the pool bar is not an invitation to dinner; a shared dinner is not an invitation to a port day. You set the pace, and on a hosted solo cruise declining doesn’t fracture anything — see the group-dynamics notes in **Section 9**.

If something feels off, Guest Services and the 24-hour security desk respond fast. Most solo cruisers go a lifetime without needing this; the option exists if you do.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise of any kind, the **first-cruise guide** is the deeper read. A few foundational notes:

- **The cabin is small.** Even a balcony cabin is smaller than a budget hotel room. You’re not living in it; you’re sleeping in it. The ship is your living room.
- **You can’t get lost.** Every elevator lobby has a deck map, and any crew member can point you. On a 12-deck ship you’ll have the layout within a day.
- **You don’t need to book everything ahead.** Most days unfold with significant unplanned time. That’s by design.
- **Tipping is built in.** Beyond the daily gratuity you don’t need to tip every interaction; a few dollars to a great bartender or steward at the end of the week is appreciated, not expected.

-
- **Don't try to do everything.** A week is enough time to do what matters. Chasing every show, every specialty meal, and every excursion will burn you out by mid-week.

The thing nobody tells first-timers: the best moments of a cruise are usually unplanned — the conversation at the pool bar on Day 3, the view from the rail at sunrise you weren't expecting, the thirty minutes watching the wake. The **Cruising Duck tradition** is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance — bring or hide a few rubber ducks if you want a friendly, accidental social ritual.

Leave room for that.

Closing

This pack is the calm read on one specific week — yours.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent — no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing.

Last reviewed | 2026-07-06 |

How facts here are checked | Every ship spec, price, date, contact number, and currency claim in this pack is checked against a primary or authoritative source — the cruise line's own published materials and FAQ (gratuities, dining), Wikipedia and shipyard/registry records for ship specs and name history, a hands-on ship review for venue detail, the U.S. Embassy in Kingston for the Cayman consular agency, and operator pages where excursions are quoted. Sources for each claim are kept in this pack's factcheck sidecar. If a number can't be sourced, it isn't asserted here. Tina's communications about her group's rhythm are quoted as hers. |

Accessibility | This pack and the site that produced it follow WCAG 2.1 AA. The Emergency Contacts section is offline-capable via the companion app so a trusted contact ashore can keep the family handoff card available without an internet

connection. See also the **disability-at-sea guide**. |

Sources | Ship: Margaritaville at Sea Islander (formerly *Costa Atlantica*); scale context via **Ship Size Atlas**, fleet context via **ships hub**. Ports: **Tampa, Grand Cayman, Ocho Rios, Cozumel, Jamaica overview**. Host + agent: **Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.**. Articles: **stateroom-sanity-check, is-drink-package-worth-it, cruise-tipping-2026, caribbean-cruise-trends-2026, cruise-cabin-organization, cruise-tech-photography-guide, cruise-seasickness-what-works, cruise-embarkation-day-what-to-expect, cruise-duck-tradition**. Tools: **drink-calculator, cruise-budget-calculator, cruise-tipping-calculator, port-day-planner, port-tracker, ship-tracker, ship-size-atlas**. Reference pages: **solo cruising hub, Solo Cruising Practical Guide, In the Wake of Grief, first-cruise, countdown, packing-lists, internet-at-sea, disability-at-sea, affiliate-disclosure**. Original research: margaritavilleatsea.com (onboard charges + FAQ), en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Margaritaville_at_Sea_Islander, gangwaze.com Islander ship stats, thepointsguy.com Islander review. |